

7 **Hindutva in Punjab**

Appropriation and Resistance

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Introduction

This chapter aims to study why Hindu nationalism has failed to take root in Punjab, a Sikh-majority state, despite the BJP being in power at the centre since 2014 and in coalition governments with the Sikh regional party Akali Dal in the state from 1997 to 2002 and from 2007 to 2017.

The regional context offers a unique set of challenges and opportunities for the Sangh Parivar. In terms of opportunities, Sikhs' cultural proximity with Punjabi Hindus and the place of the Sikh community as the sword-arm of Hinduism in the Hindutva ideological framework have allowed the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS, a Hindu nationalist paramilitary organisation) and its affiliates to make some limited inroads in the Punjab, most notably during the Akali-BJP coalition government years.

However, they have met with a strong and sustained resistance from Sikhs, whose well-known capacity to mobilise against any perceived threat to their identity is compounded by a regional political culture with a tradition of resisting the centralising urge of the Union government. Recent developments have strengthened anti-Hindutva politics in Punjab – this was notably the case during the Indian farmers' protest of 2020–2021, thanks to a unique convergence of socio-political forces staunchly opposing the ruling party's authoritarian and pro-corporate turn. The BJP IT cell smear campaign portraying the protesting farmers as Khalistanis or Naxalites bore the imprint of Hindutva's strategy towards the Sikhs: when they resist forced assimilation, the 'protectors of Hindus' become enemies of the nation and are treated as such.

This chapter will first address the roots of Hindu nationalism in Punjab and the fierce controversies and conflicts opposing Sikh and Hindu socio-religious reform movements during the colonial period, highlighting how they have shaped contemporary debates about Sikh identity and its relation to Hinduism.

Secondly, I will discuss how the Hindu nationalist strategy vis-à-vis Punjab and the Sikhs entails both sustained efforts to incorporate them, particularly through a rewriting of Sikh history, and, when met with resistance, to aggressively project them as anti-nationals by mechanically raising the spectre of Khalistan separatism.

Finally, Sikh responses and anti-Hindutva mobilisation in the wake of the Indian farmers' movement will be briefly analysed, and the impact of the normalisation of Hindutva and the neoliberal majoritarian turn of the ruling party on the Punjab and the Sikhs will be discussed.¹

Historical Background: From Arya Samaj to Singh Sabha Controversies in the Nineteenth Century to the Punjabi Suba Movement

To understand Sikhs' current resistance to the Hindutva project of assimilating them, one needs to discuss their relationships with Hindu nationalists since the nineteenth century, particularly

the controversies and conflicts opposing Sikh and Hindu socio-religious reform movements that have shaped contemporary debates.

Since their inception in the second half of the nineteenth century, the Arya Samaj and the Singh Sabha have indeed engaged in fierce controversies about Sikh identity and its relation to Hinduism.

Founded by Swami Dayanand in Gujarat in 1875, the aim of the Arya Samaj was to promote a reformed Hinduism, based on the infallibility of the Vedas and free of practices such as idolatry, child marriage and Brahmin domination. It became particularly influential among the Punjabi Hindu urban middle classes, which provided most of its leadership (Jones 1973). The first Singh Sabha was created in Amritsar in 1873 as a response to the conversion of four Sikh students to Christianity, the Namdhari unrest and the perceived decline of Sikhism, and to act as a representative of Sikh interests before the colonial government.

In his authoritative account of the complex relationships between Aryas and Sikh reformists, Kenneth Jones highlights a gradual shift from cooperation to conflict (Jones 1973). Initially, several members of the Lahore Singh Sabha had even joined the Samaj, attracted by its reformist zeal and dynamism. They shared a common concern regarding Christian and Muslim proselytism, which initially served as the basis for their cooperation before becoming a bone of contention between the two organisations (Jones 1973). Indeed, Aryas reappropriated the traditional Hindu purification ritual of *shuddhi*, which they transformed into a powerful tool of reconversion and a technique of purification and uplift of untouchables to stop them from leaving the ranks of Hinduism (Clémentin-Ojha 1994). When they led *shuddhi* campaigns among Sikh untouchable caste groups, such as the Rahtia Sikhs, who were won over by the Samaj in 1900, this initiated a fierce rivalry between the two organisations (Jones 1973).

In the context of the above polemics and conflicts, Arya Samaj's contention that Sikhs constitute a branch of Hinduism – one that has failed in its original reformist ambitions according to Dayanand – accelerated the Singh Sabha's self-awareness and its redefinition of Sikh identity as separate from Hinduism (Moliner 2011). It also shaped Sikh reformists' perception of Arya activism as the greatest of all the threats facing the Panth.

A foundational text of Hindu nationalism, *Essentials of Hindutva*, by Savarkar (1923), clearly articulates Hindutva's view of the Sikhs as sons of the soil.² This sixty-seven-page document contains no less than thirty references to Sikhs, clubbed together with Jains, Sanatanis (orthodox Hindus), Arya Samajis and various Hindu sectarian and caste groups, all of them part of the Hindu nation, 'all suffered as Hindus and triumphed as Hindus' (Savarkar 1923: 58). Savarkar's racial definition of a Hindu gives a special place to Sikhs: he terms them as 'natural Hindus'³ (Savarkar 1923: 59), since they are, according to him, the most direct descendants of the Aryans, 'proud of being Hindus by race and by nationality', whose 'Hindutva is self-evident' (Savarkar 1923: 59). He concedes Sikhs a separate religious identity, whereas he insists that 'all of us racially and nationally and culturally are a polity and a people, one and indivisible' (Savarkar 1923: 59).

Hindutva's rhetoric about Sikhs being part of the Hindu fold was consolidated by the mass violence of the 1947 partition, which mostly opposed Sikhs and Hindus on one side against Muslims on the other side. As argued in a polemical pamphlet written in 1955 by a former member of the All-India Hindu Mahasabha (the first Hindu nationalist organisation, created in 1915), in the wake of the Punjabi Suba movement, partition violence, which is perceived as the re-enactment of past conflicts opposing sons of the soil and Muslims, served as a powerful reminder for Sikhs about which camp they belong to – that of the Hindu Nation:

A Sikh deceives none except himself if he regards Muslims as his better friends than Hindus. . . . For a Muslim, they are all 'Kafirs' or Hindus. . . . The academic discussion,

whether Sikhs or Buddhists are Hindus or not, is a peace time luxury. At the time of war, everybody at once comes to know . . . which camp he belongs to.

(Kahol 1955: 14, quoted in Moliner 2011)

Another point of his argument is crucial for our understanding of the role played by Sikhs in the Hindutva ideological framework: to concede a separate identity to Sikhs and other sons of the soil threatens the unity of the Hindu nation, which is then reduced to a 'conglomerate of minorities . . . numbering a few lakhs fighting each other under a powerful despotic majority, the Muslims' (Kahol 1955: 34). The author concludes: 'We are a majority against the Muslims if we are Hindus. But we become a minority the moment we discard that unifying word and start our life as Jains, Sikhs or Sanatanists' (Kahol 1955: 35).

This is an expression of the majoritarian complex of inferiority among Hindus vis-à-vis Muslims, which has been analysed by Jaffrelot and others as one of the core dimensions of Hindutva rhetoric (Jaffrelot 1996). In the case of Punjabi Hindus, this sentiment takes a particular salience following the redrawing of state boundaries and the creation of a Sikh-majority state in 1966, where they represent a minority. In Punjab, Hindu demographic anxiety and politics of fear have aimed at Sikhs and not at Muslims, as in the rest of the country. Singh offers an insightful conceptualisation of the duality of the majority-minority complex among Punjabi Hindus and Sikhs: representing a majority in the whole of India but a minority in Punjab, Punjabi Hindus 'suffer from a minority persecution complex in that state and a majority complex in the country as a whole' (Singh 1982: 46–52). Sikhs are in a diametrically opposed situation: representing a tiny religious minority in India, their strong attachment to Punjab is 'born from their minority persecution complex in India', which, in turn, instils fear and a sense of alienation among Punjabi Hindus (Singh 1982: 46–52). As a result, the latter have remained indifferent, if not hostile, to Punjab's demands for more autonomy, seen as Sikhs' demands. This duality is complexified by Sikhs' heightened demographic anxiety, related to their diminishing ratio in the state's population, due to their very high rate of overseas migration and the rising number of (Hindu) migrants from Bihar and Uttar Pradesh settling down in Punjab.

The next section will study the *modus operandi* of the Sangh Parivar ('the family' of Hindu nationalist organisations) in contemporary Punjab, particularly with respect to Sikhs.

Protectors of Hindus or Khalistanis? Hindutva's Contradictory Invocations of Sikhs

Today, the Sangh Parivar operates in Punjab mainly through three clusters of organisations: the RSS and its affiliates, the Arya Samaj and the BJP.

The Arya Samaj, which has been so instrumental in shaping Punjabi Hindu consciousness and imposing a communal type of politics in pre-partition Punjab, retains only a shadow of its former influence. It has mostly perpetuated itself through a network of educational institutions, the Dayanand Anglo-Vedic (DAV) schools and colleges, which cater for the Punjabi urban elites (Moliner 2011).

The RSS has been present in the Punjab since its inception in the 1920s and was particularly active in pre-partition West Punjab (now Pakistan) and among Hindu post-partition refugees after independence. Most of the RSS pan-Indian affiliates operate in the state, such as the Vishwa Hindu Parishad (VHP) and its youth wing, the Bajrang Dal, as well as the Shiv Sena, while a unique organisation, the Rashtriya Sikh Sangat, was launched to propagate among the Sikh masses the idea that they belong to the Hindu fold (Moliner 2011).

During the Sikh militancy period in the 1980s and 1990s, most of these organisations went underground or stopped operating completely. Probably unprecedented in the history of the

organisation, the RSS *shakhas* ('branches') even had to discontinue their daily meetings in several major cities of the state, as their members feared for their lives. The end of militancy and the 1997 electoral alliance between the BJP and the Akali Dal enabled the revival of an almost defunct Sangh Parivar, which benefitted from government patronage until the 2020–2021 farmers' protest completely reshuffled the cards again.

Created in 1984 in the aftermath of the anti-Sikh pogroms in Delhi, the Rashtriya Sikh Sangat has worked consistently at expanding the Sangh's presence in Punjab. To incorporate Sikhs within Hinduism, it has made extensive use of the religious iconography, juxtaposing, for instance, Sikh and Hindu symbols and visual representations. On banners, posters and pamphlets, the Hindu symbol *Om* is routinely placed side by side with the Sikh symbol *Ek Onkar*, and Sikh Gurus are depicted next to Hindu deities and presented in the Sangat literature as their avatars. Copies of the *Adi Granth* (Sikh sacred scriptures) have been installed in mandirs to conduct *akhand path* (a ceremony consisting of the continuous recitation of the *Adi Granth*) or carried during religious processions (*nagar kirtan*), until the Sikh supreme religious authority, the Akal Takht, banned such activities (Moliner 2011). However, according to independent media reports (see, for instance, Dogra 2017), the Rashtriya Sikh Sangat has become almost defunct in Punjab, firstly incapacitated by the 2004 Akal Takht's edict forbidding Sikhs from maintaining any relation with the organisation and secondly, following the assassination of its president, Rulda Singh, shot by Khalistani militants in 2009 (Dogra 2017).

Since then, the Sangh Parivar has developed a two-pronged strategy with respect to the Sikhs: on the one hand, it has intensified its efforts at incorporating them, using the community to serve its own agenda, and on the other hand, it treats Sikhs challenging the BJP and asserting their cultural autonomy as anti-nationals, branding them as Khalistanis. As we are going to discuss below, the latter dimension seems to have taken precedence in the wake of the Indian farmers' protest of 2020–2021.

As part of its politics of assimilation of the Sikhs, the RSS has consistently strived to rewrite Sikh history to project the community as the sword-arm of the Hindu nation in the centuries-old struggle with Muslims, and in that context, Sikh martyrs have received specific attention. Official commemorations of Sikh figures have served as the prime space for the historical revisionism and assimilationist efforts of the Sangh Parivar, at the epicentre of which stands the ninth Sikh Guru, Guru Tegh Bahadur. As I have discussed elsewhere, his death under the orders of the Mughal emperor Aurangzeb has given rise to diverse and contested interpretations throughout history (Moliner 2011). According to Sikh historical accounts, Kashmiri Brahmins, who were threatened with forced conversion by Aurangzeb, appealed to the ninth Guru, who rose to their rescue and, having refused to convert to Islam, was decapitated in 1675. As per the Sikh interpretation of the event, a religiously motivated conflict opposed a fanatical Muslim tyrant⁴ and the Sikh Guru, ready to sacrifice his life for the sake of religious freedom, in that particular instance, of a community other than his own (Singh 2017). On the contrary, Hindu nationalists argue that the Guru died to protect his own *dharma* ('religion'), the Hindu *dharma*, and his martyrdom substantiates their claim about Sikhs being an integral part of the Hindu fold. This interpretation has been repeatedly brought to the fore by Hindutva forces, both at the state and national levels, as part of their politics of commemoration and reclaiming of the Sikh past. For instance, in its special issue for the tercentenary celebrations of the Khalsa, in 1999, *Organiser*, the RSS mouthpiece, argued:

The martyrdom of Guru Tegh Bahadur clearly indicates what the identity of [a] Sikh means: Sikh identity is solely and firmly established in the form of protecting the Hindu society and the Hindu dharma.

(*Organiser* 1999, quoted in Moliner 2011)

In April 2022, the BJP-led Union government organised a grand two-day event at the Red Fort to celebrate the 400th birth anniversary of the ninth Sikh Guru in the presence of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Home Minister Amit Shah. The choice of the site itself was of highly symbolic significance: according to the Union culture ministry, the co-convenor (with the Delhi Gurdwara Management Committee) of the event, this is where the Mughals had ordered the execution of the Guru – the celebrations enacting a form of historical revenge against Muslims, bringing Sikhs and Hindus together. Hindutva's portrayal of Sikhs as protecting Hindus from an inherently intolerant and tyrannical Muslim rule imbibed the celebrations. In his speech, PM Modi, for instance, stated that, during the Guru's time, 'there was a storm of religious intolerance', 'a zenith of violence and atrocities in the name of religion' and 'in front of Aurangzeb's tyrannical thinking, Guru Tegh Bahadur became "Hind ki Chadar" and stood like a rock' (Organiser 2022).

In his coverage of the event, *India Today's* journalist, Harmeet Shah Singh, pointed out what he called the historical revisionism and cultural appropriation at stake here, through the evolving titles bestowed upon the Guru, from *Srishti ki Chadar* ('protector of humanity') in seventeenth-century Sikh poetic texts to *Dharam ki Chadar* ('protector of religion') a hundred years ago to *Hind ki Chadar* ('protector of India') currently (Singh 2022). According to Sagar (2021), a book published in 2017 goes one step further in this distortion of Sikh history, with the title *Hindu ki Chadar, Shri Guru Tegh Bahadur ji* ('Shield of Hindus, Shri Guru Tegh Bahadur'). Speaking at the launch of the book, RSS joint general secretary reiterated Hindutva's rhetoric: 'Had Guru Tegh Bahadur not sacrificed his life the entire India would have converted into Islam and our ancient culture and civilization would have ended' (Sagar 2021).

The Hindutva politics of religious revanchism and historical revisionism, which recently led to the erasure of Mughal history from class 12th history textbooks, have also resulted in attempts at implicating the Sikh community in the legal dispute surrounding the Babri Masjid. The 1045-page judgement rendered on 9 November 2019 by the Supreme Court in favour of the very Hindu organisations accused of demolishing the mosque relies indeed on the testimony of a Sikh 'expert' produced by the Hindu party. According to this expert, Guru Nanak visited Ayodhya in 1510–1511, during his extensive *udasis* ('travels'), and worshipped at the alleged birthplace of Lord Ram, arguably proving that a temple visited by devotees stood there and was demolished a few years later to build the Babri Masjid (Dogra 2019). The judgement also refers to an 1858 court case about the intrusion into the mosque of a group of Nihangs, who performed *puja* for several days there and wrote the name of Ram with charcoal on the walls of the building (Dogra 2019). This much-discussed judgement from the highest legal authority of the country both denies Sikhs a separate religious identity (presenting them as worshipping Ram and calling them a 'cult') and uses them to strengthen the Hindu side's claim on the disputed site.

More broadly speaking, Sikhs have been forcibly enlisted in a subordinate position in Hindutva's rewriting of Indian history as a history of subjugation of Hindus under 1,200 years of Muslim rule and in its project of restoring the Hindu Nation to its supposed former glory.

Faced with increasing Sikh resistance, particularly during the Kisan Andolan (Indian farmers' protest) of 2020–2021, the Sangh Parivar has now strengthened the second strand of its tactics regarding Sikhs: whenever they resist Hindutva's attempts at assimilating them or oppose the ruling party's neoliberal policies and authoritarian populism, Sikhs become enemies and attract charges of being terrorists and anti-nationals (Bal 2023). As I write, in the wake of the India–Canada row, agitating the spectre of Khalistan and projecting Sikhs as enemies and a threat to the nation have become the dominant tropes in the Sangh Parivar rhetoric.

In 2020–2021, against what has been described as the most massive and sustained challenge and the only successful one to the ruling party, Hindutva forces deployed the whole array of

coercive measures at their disposal against the protesting farmers, including *lathi* charges by the Haryana police during the initial stages of the march to Delhi, vigilante violence at the Singhu border by a mob comprising BJP supporters posing as locals (Zubair 2021) and charges of sedition and arrest warrants for thousands of farmers, union leaders and journalists. In addition to state and vigilante violence, the ruling party elaborated a sustained and particularly aggressive media campaign defaming the protesters, starting by ridiculing them as uneducated and simple-minded farmers who had failed to understand the benefits of the farming laws. Soon after, the propaganda machine of the BJP and its IT cell accused the protesters of being funded by Khalistanis (themselves manipulated by Pakistan) and infiltrated by Naxalites. The repeated invocations of both movements, associated in public imagination with violence and terrorism, were aimed at delegitimising the Andolan and having the largely supportive public opinion turn its back on the farmers (Nielsen and Nilsen 2025).

The Khalistan spectre soon became the dominant trope in the official narrative about the protest, particularly after the Red Fort incident, when, as part of the march to Delhi organised by the farmers' unions on the occasion of Republic Day (26 January 2021), a group of protesters took an alternative route and unfurled the Nishan Sahib (Sikh flag) in the Red Fort. As argued by Nielsen and Nilsen, this campaign was 'entirely in line with the political grammar of Modi's authoritarian populism, which . . . is predicated on imagined fault lines between an authentic Indian people and their enemies within – the anti-national Other' (Nielsen and Nilsen 2025).

Hence, since the Andolan, Hindutva forces are both striving to assimilate Sikhs through the commemorative politics and distortion of the Sikh past that I discussed above, as well as consistently raising the spectre of Khalistan, including in the international arena, such as during the diplomatic row with Canada over the assassination in Canada of the Khalistani activist, Hardeep Singh Nijjar. As incisively written by *The Caravan* editor, in Hindutva's world-view, 'the Sikhs are a *gale ki haddi*, the proverbial bone stuck in the RSS gullet, which can neither be swallowed nor ejected' (Bal 2023).

In Punjab, the Shiv Sena seems to be tasked with inciting communal tensions with Sikh radical groups through overtly provocative statements while being shielded by police protection. In the wake of clashes between Hindu and Sikh groups, in May 2022, Nikhil Rampal, from *The Print*, conducted an investigation and found out that there are as many as fifteen homegrown Shiv Senas in the state, without registration or connection to the Marathi Shiv Sena founded by Thackeray (Rampal 2022). While the latter primarily targeted Muslims and non-Marathis, the former's obsessive focus is on a supposed threat posed by Khalistanis. The political leaders interviewed by the journalist (including the Punjab unit's president of the Maharashtra-based Shiv Sena) stated that 'these self-styled Shiv Senas have no political legitimacy, do not contest elections, and have no purpose other than to instigate conflicts with Sikh groups' (Rampal 2022).

Sikh Responses to Hindutva in the Wake of the Kisan Andolan

Two turning points in the recent political history of India, namely the anti-CAA protests and the Indian farmers' protest, have been catalysts of anti-Hindutva mobilisation in Punjab, particularly among Sikhs. The Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA), which sought to redefine Indian citizenship along communal lines and turn Indian Muslims into second-class citizens, was met with massive protests throughout the country, from December 2019 to February 2020.

Punjab was the second state in the country to pass a resolution against the act (on 17 Jan 2020), while the Akal Takht Jathedar expressed his full support to the (mostly Muslim) protesters on behalf of the Sikh community (The Hindu 2020). The Punjabi Left, with farmers' unions, trade

unions, lawyers and students' organisations, along with the Muslim population of Malerkotla, was the driving force behind the anti-CAA mobilisation in the state, with two mass rallies organised in Malerkotla in February 2020. From their home districts of Bathinda and Mansa, Punjabi farmers from the Punjab Kisan Union (PKU) regularly joined the protest site of Shaheen Bagh in Delhi, while local Sikhs served *langar* ('community kitchen') to the protesters. A new figure of resistance to Hindu majoritarianism and its attempt at pitting one minority against another had emerged from the unlikely alliance between Sikh farmers and Muslim housewives.

A few months after the anti-CAA mobilisation, the Indian farmers' protest witnessed another alliance that accounted for much of its success, that of two political forces traditionally viewed as antagonistic, the Punjabi Left and Sikh nationalists, united in their deep-rooted opposition against the centralising, pro-corporate and authoritarian turn of the ruling party. While the left-ist farmers' unions played an instrumental role in the logistics at the protest sites and in creating awareness among the rural masses about the negative impacts the laws would have had on the agrarian economy, the appeal to Sikh identity and values and the community's history of struggle against perceived injustice and tyranny proved the most formidable resource that sustained the protesters' motivation for over a year. The protest also echoed the long-standing contestations and debates about Sikh identity discussed above. Sikhs' minority status and their resistance against the Hindutva project of reclaiming them formed a major rallying point in the protest, while having a powerful transnational appeal among the Sikh Diaspora (Moliner 2025).

Several commentators have argued that the alliances forged at the grass-roots level across the caste, class and communal divides during the protest might represent the most powerful form of resistance to Hindutva. It has certainly strengthened popular modes of resistance to Hindutva in Punjab, as well as in the Diaspora.

However, sections of the Sikh elite well integrated within the Indian state apparatus are tempted to choose a different path and align with the majority community for their own benefit. This is exemplified by the political trajectory of a senior SAD leader and ex-president of the Delhi Gurdwara Management Committee, Manjinder Singh Sirsa. After being one of the most vocal opponents of the farm laws and the BJP government during the farmers' protest, Sirsa joined the ruling party after the repeal of the laws in December 2021. This was perceived then as an attempt by the BJP to woo Sikhs and mitigate its unpopularity a few months before the 2022 elections. Since then, Sirsa has become a key piece in the ruling party's strategy vis-à-vis the Sikhs, tasked to propagate among them the idea that they have everything to gain with PM Modi and Hindutva, while raising at will the Khalistan spectre.

As I write these concluding lines, Punjab's farmers' unions have launched on 13 February 2024 a new agitation to press for the implementation of PM Modi's promise to legalise Minimum Support Price (MSP) for their crops. To prevent them from reaching Delhi, several entry points have been fortified by erecting cement blocks, stone boulders, spikes and barbed wires (Mushtaq and Lohia 2024). In an unprecedented deployment, Haryana police forces and paramilitary troops at the Shambhu border (between Punjab and Haryana) have used rubber pellets, tear gas shells and even drones, resulting in severe injuries among the protesters and the death of an elderly farmer by cardiac arrest and of a 21-year-old young farmer, Shubhkaran Singh, due to a head injury caused by a rubber bullet. One can argue that the BJP government's ultra-repressive response would have been different had this movement not been launched by Sikh farmers: their stiff resistance, symbolised by those defiant protesters flying kites at the Shambhu border, will most certainly reinforce anti-Hindutva and anti-BJP sentiment in Punjab and among Sikhs, merely a few weeks before the general elections are due to start. And the BJP's response to the agitation attests to the ruling party's increasingly coercive strategy towards Sikhs, which has now taken precedence over their assimilationist approach and should serve as a reminder to

sections of the Sikh elite tempted by incorporation into the Hindu majoritarian agenda that, as Bal incisively puts it, ‘this Hindu Rashtra can just as easily turn against them, and in fact does under the guise of the Khalistan Label as and when it chooses’ (Bal 2023).

Notes

- 1 This chapter, particularly its historical section, borrows from an earlier publication on the complex relationships between Hindu nationalists and the Sikhs from the colonial period till the early 2000s (Moliner 2011).
- 2 In a very comprehensive article about the RSS attitude towards Sikhs during the Kisan Andolan, Sagar quotes extensively from Hindutva’s foundational text (Sagar 2021).
- 3 Quoted in Sagar (2021).
- 4 For a nuanced approach to this historical figure, much vilified both by the proponents of Hindutva and in Sikh collective memory, see A. Truschke (2017).

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